Nigger

By Charlayne Woodard

"ABC Song" plays. Lights up on CHARLAYNE as she mimes jumping rope across the stage, singing along with the music.

INTRODUCTION

***The N-word** is the word **"nigger"**, one of the three truly taboo words left in Standard English today. It means a black person but has behind it hundreds of years of white racist contempt, particularly when it comes out of the mouth of a white person. In this selection, I want to take you back to the 1960's a time when de-segregation was in its infancy and a young African American girl experiences the word for the first time . . . . The words of wisdom from her mother do not excuse the racial intent behind the situation, but they do ring true for those of us who face small-minded people everywhere – based on the color of our skin, our gender, our sexual orientation or the myriad of differences that make our society unique. Stand strong, little "rabbit pellet." Nigger by Charlayne Woodard.*

CHARLAYNE: " ... H-I-J-K-L-M-MINTO-P!"

(Boasting.) I learned my ABC's in one night! Thanks to my Aunt Ruby, who gave me a big, beautifully illustrated ABC book, and thanks to my father, who taught them to me.

One night, after dinner, Daddy said, "Charlayne, go get me that big pretty ABC book and meet me on the couch." *(Moving loveseat stage left.)* I did this. *(Sitting on the loveseat:)* I sat next to Daddy and he opened that big pretty book on both of our laps.

He said "This is an A. This is a B. This is a C. This is a D. What is this, Charlayne?" *(Daddy slaps her on the back of her hand. She's shocked.)*

"This is an A. This is a B. This is a C. This is a D. What is this, Charlayne?"

"This is an A, this is a B, this' is a C, this is a D. Pay attention, Charlayne. What is this, Charlayne?"

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"A?"

"Very good, Charlayne. And what is this?"

"B?"

"Very good, Charlayne. And what is this?"

"D?" *(Slaps her hand, then more slaps for emphasis.)*

This . . . went . . . on . . . all . . . night . . . long . . . until sunrise, when finally I could identify every letter of the alphabet, backwards, forwards, and out of sequence.

Mommy was mortified, but Daddy was determined. My sister, Allie, had watched as much she could from underneath the coffee table in front of' us. Then she fell asleep and Mommy put her to bed late that night.

The next morning at breakfast, Daddy said, "Allie, tonight *you're* gonna learn *your* ABC's."

I teased her, I taunted her all day long. *(Singsong.)* "Allie's gonna learn her ABC's tonight! Allie's gonna learn her ABC's tonight!"

Allie tried desperately to be brave. She said *(feigning glee),* "Hip, hip hooray! Hip, hip hooray!"

That evening at dinner Allie hardly ate a thing. I wonder why ....

After dinner, Daddy said, "Allie, go get that big, pretty ABC book and meet me on the couch."

Allie took my place, right next to Daddy on the couch *(sitting on loveseat)* and I took her place right up under that coffee table.

Daddy opened that big, pretty book on both of their laps.

"This is an A, this is a B, this is a C, this is a D. What is this, Allie?"

My sister wailed! My sister screamed! My sister wept crocodile

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tears! Then, she started peeing on the couch. *(Standing.)* "Get her off my couch, Woody!" Mommy screamed. "Get her off my couch!"

Then Allie peed all over the living-room rug.

Oooh! Mommy was furious ... but not with Allie. Oh no.

"See what you did, Woody?! This is all *your* fault. You know . . . you know you can't put Allie under any pressure! *(To Allie:)* Mama's little baby Come on, Allie ... let Mama clean you up. Yes, yes It's all over, Allie. *(She glares at Daddy.)* It's all over.

So . . . when I entered kindergarten; I could already read. My sister Allie can't read to this day! Just kidding!

But as a result of my reading ability, at the beginning of third grade, I was placed into an accelerated program. It was called the "AT." We were "academically talented!"

So on the first day of school, instead of Mommy walking me and Allie up Second Street to School 6, she and Allie walked me *down* Second Street to the bus stop, where I'd catch the bus that was to take me all the way across town to my new school-School 20.

At the bus stop my mother gave me a pep talk-of sorts. She said, "Charlayne, your job is to be smart. Your job is to do your schoolwork, do whatever your teacher tells you to do, and do it well. Now, the other kids in your class will probably have a lot of help from their parents, from their older sisters and brothers. You won't have any help. Your parents are working so hard to take care of this family, we are working round the clock to pay the bills, to give you and Allie a comfortable life. But you've got the right stuff to do this on your own, otherwise they wouldn't have chosen you. Yes?" *(Thinking)* "I'm gonna do it, Mommy!"

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The bus came and my mother kissed me on my forehead.

I boarded that bus *(sitting on the loveseat, which is now the bus)* and I waved to them. I waved to them until I couldn't *see* them anymore. I tell you, this "right stuff" was turning out to be a double-edged sword. While I was ready for the challenge, here I was being taken away from everything I knew and loved: my neighborhood, my friends, my school, and most of all, my Allie.

Oh, but the difference between School 6 and School 20 was like night and day.

First of all, there were only sixteen kids in my classroom! And they said it would stay this way until seventh grade. Second of all, Randy French and I were the only two *negro* kids in the whole school. But I looked forward to making new friends. And I did! Barbara O'Dooley, Linda Fraley, and myself, we were inseparable.

I loved my teacher, Mrs. Rosenblatt. I loved all the work she gave me, and I put all my books and papers in a big red-plaid book bag that Daddy'd bought me for the first day of school.

Oh ... ! One day at recess, some classmates and I were about to race across the schoolyard.

Mrs. Rosenblatt stood way up at the finish line, with her arms outstretched. She yelled, "Get on your mark . . ." *(CHARLA YNE gets into a starting position.)* "Get set ... "

Then I heard another voice ring out. *(Singsong)* "Run, nigger, run!" "Get set ... " *(Singsong)* "Run, nigger, run."

This time I recognized the voice. It was Barbara O'Dooley . . . . Mrs. Rosenblatt yelled, "Charlayne, you've got to get on your mark!"

And I told her, "I'm not running!"

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Then Barbara yells out so everyone can hear, "Why not? My father said that all niggers. can run fast!"

Well, Mrs. Rosenblatt did the running that day! She raced across that schoolyard, grabbed Barbara O'Dooley by the arm, and marched her up those stairs and into that classroom.

No one had ever called me that name before! It felt as if somebody had come up behind me and punched me in my back. The other kids thought it was very funny. They were all laughing. It felt as if they were all calling me ....

That day, for the first time since school started, I couldn't wait for that school bus to come and take me away from School 20. When I got home, my mother was working in the garden out by the peach tree. . *(Angry to the point of tears;)* .

"Mommy! Mommy, they called me a nigger today in school, Mommy! Barbara O'Dooley said, 'Run, nigger, run.'" My mother put down her tools, took off her gloves, she stood up, and she ... started laughing! She laughed and she laughed. She couldn't stop laughing! *(Confused.)* "Mommy! Please ... !"

Finally, my mother collected herself. She looked around the yard. "Charlayne, what if I were to call you a ... rabbit pellet? *(Singsong.)* Run, rabbit pellet, run!"

"No, Mommy! That's not what they said! They called me-"

"Okay, what if I were to call you ... a stinkweed? Come on over here, stinkweed, and give Mama some sugar!"

"Mommy, please, you're being silly!"

"Yes. I am being silly. But if I'm silly enough to call you a stinkweed,

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does that make you a stinkweed . . . ? Huh . . . ? Are you a stinkweed?" *(CHARLAYNE takes this in.)*

And then I looked around the yard. *(Tentatively;)* "You're a peach pit, Mommy!"

"And you're a rabbit pellet!"

(Circling the loveseat, which is now the peach tree, delighted.) "Peach pit!"

"Rabbit pellet!" "Stinkweed!"

"Froggy face!"

My mother chased me round and round that peach tree as we called each other the most ridiculous names, until finally we just fell out on the grass *(collapsing to the stage),* exhausted. Then my mother crawled over to me. She said, "Charlayne, 'nigger' is just a word-a word that people purposely made up so they can sling it at us whenever they want to hurt us, whenever they want to *stop* us from doing what we should and being who we are. Now think. Why would Barbara want to hurt you?"

"Because I was going to win that race ... ? Like I always do?"

"Did you win?"

"No, Mommy, I couldn't even run."

"So . . . Barbara beat you today. And all because of that silly word."

(Pause.) And then I understood.

"Charlayne, if anybody wants to call you a rabbit pellet, you just let them . . . and secretly laugh to yourself: 'How silly *they* are!' Because you know you are not a rabbit pellet, you are not a stinkweed. . . ."

(CHARLA YNE stands with the realization;) "And, Mommy . .. I am not ... a nigger."

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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